

The way to avoid the ills of the narrative fallacy is to favor experimentation over storytelling, experience over history, and clinical knowledge over theories. Certainly the newspaper cannot perform an experiment, but it can choose one report over another—there is plenty of empirical research to present and interpret from—as I am doing in this book. Being empirical does not mean running a laboratory in one’s basement: it is just a mind-set that favors a certain class of knowledge over others. I do not forbid myself from using the word *cause*, but the causes I discuss are either bold speculations (presented as such) or the result of experiments, not stories.

Another approach is to predict and keep a tally of the predictions.

Finally, there may be a way to use a narrative—but for a good purpose. Only a diamond can cut a diamond; we can use our ability to convince with a story that conveys the right message—what storytellers seem to do.

So far we have discussed two internal mechanisms behind our blindness to Black Swans, the confirmation bias and the narrative fallacy. The next chapters will look into an external mechanism: a defect in the way we receive and interpret recorded events, and a defect in the way we act on them.

* The word *the* is written twice.

* The Parisian novelist Georges Perec tried to break away from narrative and attempted to write a book as large as the world. He had to settle for an exhaustive account of what happened on the Place Saint-Sulpice between October 18 and October 20, 1974. Even so, his account was not so exhaustive, and he ended up with a narrative.

* Such tests avoid both the narrative fallacy and much of the confirmation bias, since testers are obliged to take into account the failures as well as the successes of their experiments.